

democracy and towards absolute dictatorship," she adds. Other PPP insiders are less diplomatic. "We told Benazir this deal was being put in place just to make a fool out of her," says a close adviser, "but she wouldn't listen to us. Now she has realised it herself."

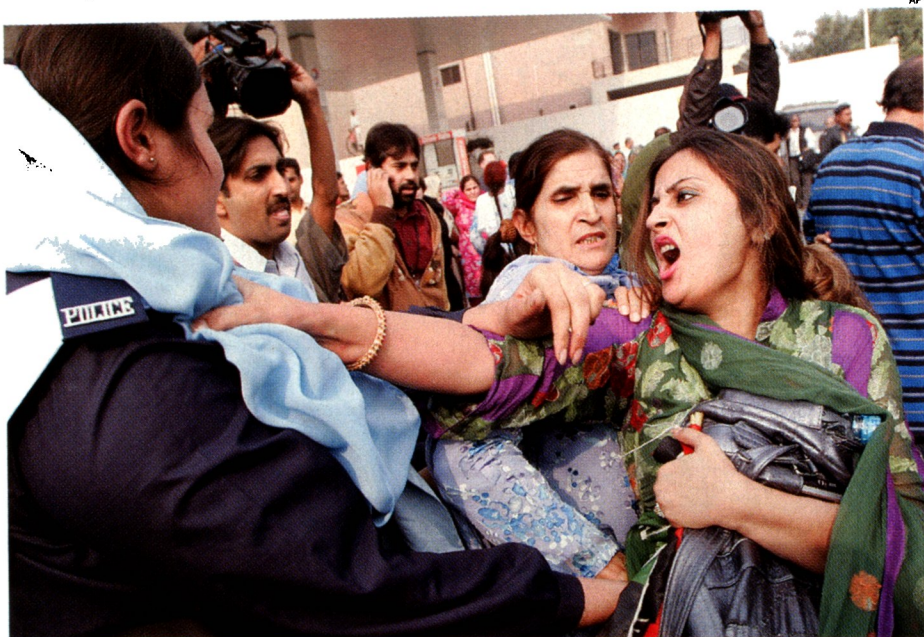
Most observers feel Bhutto gave in to increasing pressure from activists, lawyers and the media and decided to clearly delineate where she stood. Her unequivocal statement in support of deposed chief justice Iftikhar Chaudhry, for example, came only after journalists badgered her over her non-committal attitude towards the judges who had been sacked for refusing to take oath under Musharraf's new Provisional Constitutional Order. The rising tide of popular sentiment against Musharraf's actions—evidenced by the unprecedented student protests—may also have convinced Bhutto that she could not risk being left behind.

PPP leaders claim that Bhutto's statement calling for Musharraf's resignation was not made with any covert American backing, as many in Pakistan believe. "We have not received any chatter on the line yet," is how one member of the PPP Central Executive Committee puts it. There are reports that officials in the White House and the US State Department are worried Bhutto may have overplayed her hand by taking too rigid a stand. But many analysts in Pakistan believe her position indicates that she thinks she can displace him through confrontational politics without much damage to herself. Certainly, a judiciary considered pliant to Musharraf would now find it difficult to take decisions against her that can be seen as fair.

The chink in Musharraf's armour may, in fact, be his own doing. By alienating large segments through the imposition of martial rule—an American International Republican Institute poll in September found 83 per cent of Pakistanis opposed the idea of Emergency—he has created the conditions for opposition from civil society activists. While lawyers are already on the warpath against him—bar councils have called for boycott of high court and supreme court judges who have taken oath under the new set-up—he has provided fresh impetus by sacking judges. The stringent curbs on the media—most of the important news channels continue to be blacked out—have turned the intelligentsia against him. Finally, by cracking down on dissent from pro-democracy moderates, he has alienated the international community. The 53-nation Commonwealth has threatened to suspend Pakistan if martial rule is not repealed, Japan has indicated that aid could be curtailed, while almost a dozen international human rights organisations, including Amnesty, Oxfam and Human Rights Watch,

have called for US military aid to Pakistan to be cut off. By pushing PPP into the arms of his implacable foes, Musharraf has now added "rowdy" politicians to the mix. Intensifying street demonstrations and civil disobedience may severely test the patience of Musharraf's colleagues within the military. On his part, he does not seem to have closed the door to rapprochement with Bhutto, though his patience with her is wearing thin. Calling her idea of a long march as "a preposterous thing to do" in a "disturbed terrorist environment", he is now also questioning her electoral support. "You come here supposedly in reconciliatory mode, and right before you land, you're in confrontationist mode," he said in an interview to *The New York Times*.

Musharraf's announcement that elections would not be delayed—contrary to the view of 68 out of 71 federal



WAVE OF DISOBEDIENCE: With the arrest of innocent citizens, civil unrest is mounting

ministers, according to insiders—may also be seen as an attempt to mitigate some of the opposition against the imposition of martial law. It is difficult to see how reconciliation is possible, however, given that Bhutto has gone far in her rhetoric. What is still uncertain is how the US sees the growing political turmoil in Pakistan. Despite their frustration with Musharraf, the Americans would not at all be comfortable with a descent into chaos that could threaten their interests in the battle against militancy in the northern areas of Pakistan and Afghanistan. US Under-Secretary of State John Negroponte—who has called Musharraf "indispensable" in the war on terror—is scheduled to arrive in Pakistan within the next few days and is likely to meet both the President and Bhutto. There are intriguing questions about how the US views Bhutto's olive branch towards hardliners such as Hussain and Khan, who have long opposed what they dub "America's war against Pakistan's own people" in the tribal areas and the Swat valley.

Will Bhutto back down if faced with US pressure or will she lead the movement to overthrow Musharraf? In either case, her decision will determine which way Pakistan goes. ■